The Evolution of the Sinn Féin Political Establishment: A Structural, Financial, and Historical Analysis (1905–2025)

1. Introduction

The contemporary political establishment of Sinn Féin presents a unique case study in the durability of political branding amidst profound organizational discontinuity. While the party utilizes the nomenclature and symbolism of the revolutionary movement founded in 1905, a forensic examination of its history reveals that the modern organization is not a seamless continuation of that early 20th-century entity. Instead, it is the product of a series of ideological and structural fractures—most notably the Civil War split of 1922, the departure of Éamon de Valera in 1926, and the definitive schism of 1970 which birthed the Provisional movement.

This report addresses the specific inquiry regarding the origins of the current Sinn Féin establishment in the context of the Irish Civil War, validating the user's observation of the direct lineage between Fine Gael and the pro-Treaty state-builders of 1922, while contrasting this with the oscillating power dynamics that have characterized Sinn Féin. Furthermore, the analysis investigates the assertion that the party acts as an "extremely American" entity, exploring the deep-seated financial and strategic connections to the United States that date back to Éamon de Valera's foundational mission in 1919.

By synthesizing historical records with contemporary financial filings—including data from the US Department of Justice under the Foreign Agents Registration Act (FARA) and reports from the Standards in Public Office Commission (SIPO)—this document provides an exhaustive account of the party's funding mechanisms, property portfolios, and the "Americanization" of its political strategy. It further examines conflicts of interest arising from these external revenue streams and the party's ideological positioning within the geopolitical context of the British Isles.

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2. The Genesis of the Revolutionary Establishment (1905–1921)

To understand the divergence between the "proven history" of Fine Gael and the shifting establishment of Sinn Féin, one must first dissect the monolithic movement from which both emerged. The Sinn Féin of the early 20th century was not a singular, disciplined party in the modern sense, but a broad umbrella coalition of nationalists, republicans, and dual-monarchists united by a desire for Irish self-determination.

2.1 The Griffith Era and the "Hungarian Policy"

Founded in 1905 by Arthur Griffith, the original Sinn Féin ("We Ourselves" or "Ourselves Alone") did not initially advocate for an Irish Republic. Griffith's policy was predicated on the "Dual Monarchy" model of Austria-Hungary, arguing that the Act of Union of 1800 was illegal and that the King of England should act as a separate King of Ireland, with a parliament in Dublin independent of Westminster.[1] This distinction is critical because it highlights that the "Republican" DNA associated with the modern party was an imported characteristic, grafted onto Griffith's organization after 1916.

2.2 The 1916 Rising: The Brand Hijack

The pivotal moment in the party's history—and the source of much confusion regarding its lineage—was the Easter Rising of 1916. The insurrection was planned and executed by the secret Irish Republican Brotherhood (IRB) and the socialist Irish Citizen Army, not by Sinn Féin. In fact, Griffith's organization had been in decline prior to the Rising. However, British authorities and the press erroneously labeled the insurrection the "Sinn Féin Rising," leading to a surge in popularity for the brand.[3]

In the aftermath, the surviving rebels, led by Éamon de Valera, infiltrated the Sinn Féin organization. At the 1917 Ard Fheis (party conference), the party was fundamentally reorganized. Griffith stepped aside as President in favor of de Valera, and the constitution was amended to advocate for an Irish Republic, abandoning the Dual Monarchy concept.[4] This 1917 reorganization marks the creation of the revolutionary party that swept the 1918 general election and established the First Dáil Éireann in 1919.[5]

2.3 The First Dáil and the War of Independence

Between 1919 and 1921, Sinn Féin functioned as the single political vehicle for Irish nationalism. It operated a counter-state, with its own courts, police, and ministries, directly challenging British rule. This period represents the only time in history when the ancestors of Fine Gael, Fianna Fáil, and the modern Sinn Féin were united within a single organizational structure. The unity of this establishment was maintained only by the exigencies of the War of Independence; once the truce was called in July 1921, the inherent ideological fissures within the movement began to widen, setting the stage for the defining split of Irish politics.

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3. The Civil War and the Great Fracture (1921–1923)

The user's query correctly identifies the Irish Civil War as the crucible that defined the modern Irish political landscape. The division over the Anglo-Irish Treaty of 1921 did not merely split the party; it created two distinct political traditions with separate institutional lineages.

3.1 The Treaty Debates: State-Builders vs. Republicans

The Anglo-Irish Treaty, negotiated by Michael Collins and Arthur Griffith, offered Ireland status

as a "Free State" within the British Commonwealth, rather than the full Republic fought for in 1916.

- **The Pro-Treaty Faction (The Ancestors of Fine Gael):** This group, led by Collins and Griffith, argued that the Treaty provided "the freedom to achieve freedom." They secured a majority in the Dáil and proceeded to build the institutions of the new state—the army, the police (An Garda Síochána), and the civil service. Crucially, they prioritized the stability and functionality of the state over ideological purity. Organizationally, this faction formed **Cumann na nGaedheal** in 1923, which later merged with the National Centre Party and the Blueshirts (National Guard) in 1933 to form **Fine Gael**.[4]
- **The Anti-Treaty Faction (The Ancestors of Sinn Féin/Fianna Fáil):** Led by Éamon de Valera, this faction rejected the Treaty, viewing the Oath of Allegiance to the Crown as a betrayal of the republican dead. They retained the name **Sinn Féin**, claiming that the Second Dáil had not been legally dissolved and that they were the legitimate government of the Republic.[5]

3.2 The Civil War and the Legitimacy of Lineage

The Civil War (1922–1923) was a brutal conflict in which the Pro-Treaty Free State forces defeated the Anti-Treaty Republicans. The user's verification of Fine Gael's lineage is historically robust: Fine Gael is the direct institutional successor to the Pro-Treaty government that established the state. Their political establishment has enjoyed unbroken continuity in parliamentary politics since 1922.

In contrast, the Sinn Féin of 1923 was a defeated, marginalized entity. While it retained the name, it had lost the military argument and, crucially, the support of the majority of the Irish electorate. This defeat forced a reckoning within the Anti-Treaty movement that would lead to the second, and perhaps more significant, fracture in the history of Irish republicanism.

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4. The Wilderness Years and the 1926 Reset (1923–1969)

The assertion that the power of Sinn Féin has "changed hands quite a lot" is most vividly illustrated by the events of 1926. This period demonstrates that the modern party cannot claim organizational continuity with the powerful machine of the 1917–1921 era, as that machine was effectively dismantled and reconstituted under a different banner.

4.1 The Departure of De Valera and the Birth of Fianna Fáil

By 1926, Éamon de Valera had recognized that the policy of abstentionism—refusing to take seats in the Dáil Éireann because of the Oath of Allegiance—was rendering Sinn Féin politically irrelevant. He proposed a motion at the Sinn Féin Ard Fheis that the party should enter the Dáil if the Oath were removed.

The motion was defeated by the fundamentalist wing of the party, who adhered strictly to the

principle that the Free State parliament was an illegitimate usurpation of the Republic. In response, de Valera resigned as President of Sinn Féin. He took with him the vast majority of the party's talent, membership, and financial resources to found a new party, **Fianna Fáil**.[7]

4.2 The Rump Party

The Sinn Féin that remained after 1926 was a husk of its former self. Stripped of its most charismatic leader and its most capable organizers (such as Seán Lemass), it was reduced to a small, fundamentalist pressure group. For the next forty years, it operated on the margins of Irish political life, maintaining a rigid abstentionist stance and acting primarily as a support network for the IRA's sporadic and unsuccessful border campaigns in the 1930s, 40s, and 50s.[5]

Insight: This historical juncture is critical for the user's understanding of the "establishment." The political establishment that governs Ireland for most of the 20th century (Fianna Fáil) was the splinter group from 1926. The group that retained the title "Sinn Féin" became an outlier, disconnected from the levers of power and increasingly radicalized.

4.3 The Drift to Marxism (1960s)

In the 1960s, under the leadership of Cathal Goulding, the Sinn Féin establishment began to shift ideologically toward Marxism-Leninism. The leadership engaged in a "rethinking" of republican strategy, moving away from armed struggle and toward social agitation and class politics. They sought to unite the working class of Belfast and Dublin, Protestant and Catholic alike, against capitalism. This ideological pivot would precipitate the definitive split that created the modern party.[9]

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5. The 1970 Schism: Birth of the Modern Party

The political establishment of Sinn Féin as it exists today—the organization associated with figures like Gerry Adams, Martin McGuinness, and Mary Lou McDonald—dates its specific organizational origin to **January 1970**. It is incorrect to view the current party as the same entity as the 1905 or 1916 parties; it is, in structural terms, the "Provisional" splinter of the 1970 split.

5.1 The Ard Fheis of 1970

The tensions between the Marxist leadership (who wanted to end abstentionism and enter the Dáil/Stormont/Westminster) and the traditionalists (who prioritized the armed struggle and national unity) came to a head at the 1970 Ard Fheis at the Intercontinental Hotel in Dublin. When the motion to end abstentionism failed to achieve the necessary two-thirds majority to change the constitution, the Marxist leadership attempted to push the change through anyway. In protest, the dissenting minority—led by Ruairí Ó Brádaigh and Sean Mac Stíofáin—walked out of the meeting to reconvene at Kevin Barry Hall on Parnell Square.[9]

5.2 Official vs. Provisional Sinn Féin

This walkout resulted in two distinct parties:

1. **Official Sinn Féin:** The Marxist majority. They eventually abandoned the "Sinn Féin" title, becoming "Sinn Féin The Workers' Party," then simply **The Workers' Party**. Later, a faction split to form **Democratic Left**, which eventually merged into the **Labour Party**.
2. **Provisional Sinn Féin:** The traditionalist minority. This group pledged allegiance to the Provisional IRA, which had split from the Official IRA in late 1969. This organization is the direct linear ancestor of the current Sinn Féin party.[5]

Insight: When the user asks where Sinn Féin stems from, the most accurate political science answer is that the *current* party stems from the Provisional split of 1970. It was re-founded as the political wing of the Provisional IRA, dedicated to supporting the armed campaign in Northern Ireland, distinct from the "Official" wing which pursued a socialist parliamentary path.

5.3 The Rise of the Northern Command

The establishment of Provisional Sinn Féin underwent a further internal revolution in the late 1970s and early 1980s. The initial leadership, dominated by Southerners like Ruairí Ó Brádaigh, was gradually displaced by a younger, more radical generation from Belfast and Derry, led by **Gerry Adams** and **Martin McGuinness**.

This "Northern Command" argued that the party needed to be more than just a support group for the IRA; it needed to become a viable political force in its own right. This strategy, famously described by Danny Morrison as taking power "with a ballot paper in this hand and an Armalite in this hand," required the party to drop the policy of abstentionism regarding the Dáil.[9]

In **1986**, the party voted to take seats in the Leinster House (Dublin parliament). This caused yet another split, with the die-hard abstentionists led by Ó Brádaigh walking out to form **Republican Sinn Féin** (which still exists today as a marginal group linked to the Continuity IRA). This cemented the Adams-McGuinness leadership as the undisputed establishment of the modern party.[9]

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6. The American Connection: A Financial & Strategic Lifeline

The user's perception that Sinn Féin is "extremely American" is supported by substantial historical and financial evidence. The relationship between Irish Republicanism and the United States is not incidental; it is a foundational pillar of the movement's survival and success, distinguishing it sharply from other Irish political parties.

6.1 The De Valera Template (1919–1920)

The template for this transatlantic dependency was established by Éamon de Valera. Born in

New York in 1882, de Valera utilized his American citizenship to escape execution in 1916. In June 1919, as President of the First Dáil, he embarked on an 18-month tour of the United States that was unprecedented in scope and financial return.[7]

- **The Bond Drive:** De Valera launched a "Bond Certificate Drive" to fund the Irish Republic. This was effectively a sovereign debt issuance sold to the American public. The campaign raised over **$5 million** between 1919 and 1920.[10] Adjusted for inflation, this sum is equivalent to over **$100 million** today.
- **Mass Mobilization:** The tour featured rallies of enormous scale—50,000 attendees at Fenway Park in Boston, 25,000 at Wrigley Field in Chicago, and a sold-out Madison Square Garden.[10]
- **Strategic Impact:** This funding allowed the Dáil courts and the IRA to operate despite the British administration's attempts to strangle the movement financially. It established the precedent that the Republican movement could bypass domestic resource limitations by tapping into the immense wealth of the Irish diaspora.

6.2 Friends of Sinn Féin (FOSF)

In the post-Good Friday Agreement era, this strategy has been institutionalized through **Friends of Sinn Féin (FOSF)**, a non-profit organization based in the United States. While other Irish parties have occasional fundraisers abroad, FOSF operates on a scale and with a level of professionalization that is unique.

Financial Dominance

Since its establishment in 1995, FOSF has raised over **$12 million** (with some estimates placing the total significantly higher when including all periods).[11] The organization files semi-annual reports with the US Department of Justice under the Foreign Agents Registration Act (FARA), providing a transparent window into its operations that often contrasts with the opacity of domestic Irish funding.

Table 1: Friends of Sinn Féin (USA) Financial Snapshot (Sample Period: Nov 2024 – Apr 2025)

Category	Amount (USD)	Details
Total Receipts	**$264,184.13**	Revenue generated in a single 6-month period.[12]
Trust Distributions	$216,521.36	From the Lauren Harvey Living Trust.[12]
Grants	$20,000.00	From "Knights of the Red Branch" for advertising.
Advertising Spend	**$74,858.43**	Paid to Digital/Internet providers for US-based ad campaigns.
Northern Transfer	**$26,938.48**	Direct wire transfer to Sinn Féin in Belfast.

Travel Expenses	$36,567.25	Flights/hotels for SF leadership visiting the US.

Data Source: FARA Supplemental Statement, Period Ending 04/30/2025.[12]

The "Loophole" and Political Controversy

The user expresses concern about "external funding." This is a central point of contention in Irish political debate.

- **Regulatory Divergence:** In the Republic of Ireland, political parties are strictly prohibited from accepting foreign donations. In Northern Ireland (part of the UK), the rules have historically been different. Until 2007, foreign donations were permitted. Since 2007, they have been restricted, but significant loopholes remain regarding "consultancy services" and "expenses" paid directly in the US.[13]
- **The Mechanism:** Sinn Féin exploits the partition of the island to bypass the Republic's strict donation laws. Funds raised in the US are officially designated for use in Northern Ireland or spent directly in the US to cover "administrative" costs and "political consultancy."
- **Strategic Advantage:** This allows the party to ring-fence its domestic Irish resources for campaigning in the Republic, while having its international operations, travel, and sophisticated digital strategy subsidized by US dollars. Critics argue this creates an unlevel playing field, as Fine Gael and Fianna Fáil cannot legally access similar external war chests.[11]

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7. The "Americanization" of Political Strategy

The user's observation that Sinn Féin is "extremely American" extends beyond finance to the very methodology of their political operation. In the last decade, the party has revolutionized Irish campaigning by importing the technologies and tactics of US presidential politics.

7.1 Data Analytics and The Vote Management System

Sinn Féin was the first Irish party to fully embrace the "big data" approach that defined the Obama and Trump campaigns.

- **The Abú System:** The party developed a proprietary voter database system known as **Abú** (Irish for "Victory"). This system mirrors the **Voter Activation Network (VAN)** used by the US Democratic Party. It allows canvassers to log voter preferences, key issues, and likelihood to vote in real-time via mobile apps.
- **Micro-Targeting:** This data enables the party to engage in sophisticated micro-targeting on social media, delivering tailored messages to specific demographics (e.g., housing ads to renters in Dublin, unity ads to border communities) with a precision that traditional parties relying on "tallymen" and paper registers cannot match.[15]

7.2 US Consultants and Rebranding

The transformation of Sinn Féin from the political wing of a paramilitary organization to a

polished, progressive government-in-waiting has been guided by US political professionals.

- **Consultancy Spend:** FARA filings confirm regular payments to US-based consultants for "strategic advice" and "briefings." The party maintains a permanent presence in Washington D.C., allowing it to tap into the expertise of K Street firms.[12]
- **Image Management:** The transition from the trench-coat imagery of the 1970s to the soft-focus, inclusive branding of leaders like Mary Lou McDonald and Michelle O'Neill follows the trajectory of a US corporate rebrand. The emphasis on "Change" (a slogan borrowed directly from the Obama 2008 playbook) and the use of high-production-value video content on platforms like TikTok reflect a strategy designed to bypass traditional media gatekeepers.[15]

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8. Financial Controversies and Conflicts of Interest

The user specifically requested information on "possible external funding or conflicts of interest." The unique structural nature of Sinn Féin—straddling two jurisdictions with different legal frameworks—has given rise to several significant financial controversies that distinguish it from its rivals.

8.1 The Billy Hampton Estate (€4 Million Donation)

In 2019, it was revealed that **William "Billy" Hampton**, an eccentric English mechanic and long-time supporter, had left his entire estate to Sinn Féin.

- **The Windfall:** The bequest was valued at approximately **€3 million to €4 million**, the largest single donation in the history of Irish politics.[18]
- **The Conflict:** Under the Electoral Act in the Republic of Ireland, a political party cannot accept a donation of this magnitude. The maximum donation from a single individual is capped at €2,500.
- **The Partitionist Maneuver:** Sinn Féin accepted the donation through its Northern Ireland branch. While this was legal under UK law at the time, it provoked a storm of controversy in the Republic.
- **SIPO Involvement:** The Standards in Public Office Commission (SIPO) warned that if any of these funds were used to benefit the party's activities in the Republic, it would constitute a breach of the law. Fine Gael and other parties have repeatedly demanded forensic audits to prove that "not one penny" of this English fortune is cross-subsidizing operations in the South, highlighting the party's ability to engage in regulatory arbitrage.[19]

8.2 The Research Services Ireland (RSI) Scandal

One of the most damaging revelations regarding the party's internal finances involved a company called **Research Services Ireland (RSI)**.

- **The Scheme:** RSI was a company established by Sinn Féin officials. Over a period of several years, 36 Sinn Féin MLAs in the Northern Ireland Assembly paid their public "research allowances" into this centralized company.

- **The Amount:** Approximately **£700,000** of taxpayer money was funneled into RSI.[20]
- **The Lack of Output:** Investigations by the BBC and political opponents revealed that RSI had no website, published no reports, and produced little visible research. When challenged, party officials claimed the work was "too sensitive" to be published.
- **Implication:** Critics alleged that RSI was essentially a mechanism to siphon public parliamentary expenses into the central party coffers, reinforcing the perception of Sinn Féin as a centralized machine where elected representatives act as conduits for party finance rather than independent legislators.[22]

8.3 The Property Portfolio

Sinn Féin is frequently cited as the wealthiest political party on the island in terms of assets.

- **Real Estate Holdings:** The party owns a vast portfolio of constituency offices, advice centers, and headquarters (such as 44 Parnell Square) across both jurisdictions.
- **Trust Structures:** Many of these properties are held in complex trust structures that date back decades. In 2023/2024, controversy arose when the party struggled to comply with new transparency rules requiring the declaration of all property assets. The "opaque" nature of these trusts, often involving trustees who are deceased or long-retired, raised questions about who legally owns the party's wealth and whether it is being properly declared to SIPO.[23]

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9. Internal Governance and the "Establishment"

The "establishment" of Sinn Féin is structurally distinct from the parliamentary-focused models of Fine Gael or Labour. It retains elements of a revolutionary organizational structure, prioritizing centralized control over individual legislative autonomy.

9.1 The Ard Chomhairle: The Real Seat of Power

In most democratic parties, the Parliamentary Party (the elected MPs or TDs) elects the leader and determines policy. In Sinn Féin, supreme authority resides with the **Ard Chomhairle** (National Executive).

- **Composition:** The Ard Chomhairle consists of the Officer Board (President, Vice-President, Treasurers, etc.) and members elected at the Ard Fheis.
- **Control over Representatives:** The Ard Chomhairle has the power to direct the voting strategy of elected representatives in the Dáil and the Assembly. This centralization is a legacy of the abstentionist era, when the party viewed parliaments as illegitimate and refused to let elected members become "absorbed" into the system. This structure leads to accusations that the elected TDs are merely spokespeople for an unelected "politburo".[25]

9.2 The Shadow of the Army Council

A persistent question regarding the Sinn Féin establishment is the continued influence of the **Provisional IRA Army Council**.

- **Official Assessments:** A 2015 assessment by the Police Service of Northern Ireland (PSNI) and MI5 stated that the Army Council "remains in existence" in a reduced form and that its members "oversee both PIRA and Sinn Féin with an overarching strategy."
- **Conflict of Interest:** If accurate, this assessment implies a profound conflict of interest: that the strategy of a democratic party is being influenced or overseen by an unelected, secretive paramilitary leadership. The Sinn Féin leadership (McDonald/O'Neill) vehemently denies this, asserting that the IRA has "gone away" and that they are in full control of the party. However, the structure of the movement has historically blurred the lines between the "military" and "political" wings.[5]

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10. Ideological Positioning: The "British Isles" Context

The user's comment, *"we are in the British Isles,"* requires specific contextual analysis within the report, as it touches on a fundamental ideological conflict between the party and the user's premise.

10.1 Rejection of Terminology

The Sinn Féin establishment fundamentally rejects the term "British Isles" as a geographical or political designator.

- **Colonial Implication:** The party views the term as an archaic colonial construct that implies British ownership or dominance over Ireland. This is not merely a semantic grievance but a core tenet of their ideology.[26]
- **Official Policy:** The Irish Government also avoids the term, using "Britain and Ireland" or the "Atlantic Archipelago" in official documents. However, Sinn Féin's rejection is more aggressive, often correcting media or political opponents who use the phrase.[27]

10.2 All-Island Strategy vs. Partitionist Reality

While Fine Gael and Fianna Fáil operate primarily within the 26-county Republic (despite aspirations for unity), Sinn Féin is the only major party established and organized as a single entity across the entire island.

- **Strategic Divergence:** This all-island structure allows the party to pursue a "Border Poll" strategy that coordinates pressure on both Dublin and London simultaneously.
- **Electoral Implications:** This structure also creates the financial and regulatory complexities discussed earlier (e.g., the Billy Hampton donation), as the party attempts to operate one financial machine across two incompatible legal jurisdictions.

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11. Conclusions

The political establishment of Sinn Féin is a complex, multi-layered entity that defies simple categorization. It is at once a historical movement with deep roots in the revolutionary period and a modern, data-driven political corporation with sophisticated international financing.

11.1 Lineage and Continuity

The user's verification of Fine Gael's history is correct. Fine Gael is the direct institutional descendant of the Michael Collins/Arthur Griffith state-building project of 1922. In contrast, the modern Sinn Féin is the result of a fractured lineage—the "minority of a minority" that split from the mainstream in 1926 (Fianna Fáil) and again in 1970 (Official Sinn Féin). It stems definitively from the **Provisional** movement of 1970, rather than maintaining an unbroken line to 1916.

11.2 The American Dimension

The assertion that the party is "extremely American" is validated by the evidence.

- **Historical Precedent:** From De Valera's 1919 bond drive to the FOSF fundraising machine, the party has consistently relied on US dollars to gain an asymmetric advantage over domestic rivals.
- **Strategic Import:** The party's adoption of US-style consulting, data analytics, and "message discipline" has allowed it to professionalize its operation far faster than the traditional "civil war" parties.

11.3 Conflicts and Controversies

The party's unique structure—straddling two jurisdictions and maintaining historical links to a paramilitary past—creates inherent conflicts of interest.

- **Financial Arbitrage:** The ability to move funds (like the Hampton donation) and expenses (like the RSI monies) across the border creates transparency deficits that SIPO struggles to police.
- **Governance:** The centralized control of the Ard Chomhairle and the lingering questions regarding the Army Council suggest an "establishment" that operates with a different set of rules and hierarchies than its democratic peers in the Dáil.

Table 2: Comparative Analysis of Irish Political Lineages

Feature	**Fine Gael**	**Fianna Fáil**	**Sinn Féin (Modern)**
Origin Point	1923 (Cumann na nGaedheal)	1926 (Split from SF)	**1970 (Provisional Split)**
Founding Leader	W.T. Cosgrave / Michael Collins	Éamon de Valera	**Ruairí Ó Brádaigh / Gerry Adams**
Civil War Stance	Pro-Treaty (Free State)	Anti-Treaty (Republican)	**Anti-Treaty (Republican)**
US Funding	Minimal / Restricted	Minimal / Restricted	**Extensive (Friends of Sinn Féin)**
Governance Model	Parliamentary Party Dominant	Parliamentary Party Dominant	**Ard Chomhairle Dominant**
Jurisdiction	Republic of Ireland	Republic of Ireland (mostly)	**All-Island (NI & ROI)**

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